election campaign committee, the first step towards making him the BJP's prime ministerial candidate. If he had to fight for his chief ministership in 2002, he also had to battle hard to lead the party in 2013. At the centre of both fights was the BJP patriarch and the man who had redefined the BJP, L.K. Advani.

Advani is one of the most complex characters in Indian politics. I had first met him during the 1990 Ayodhya rath yatra, a seminal moment in his political career. Till then, he was seen as an organizational man, not a mass leader. The yatra imbued him with a certain nationalist machismo and transformed him into the ideological mascot of militant Hindutva nationalism. And yet, he would often be discomfited with the description. In one interview he told me, 'I don't know why the media keeps referring to me as a Hindu militant. There is not a trace of militancy in me.' He then looked at his devoted wife Kamala and daughter Pratibha for endorsement. They both nodded in agreement.

Maybe Advani was the victim of an image trap, especially after the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992. Maybe he was simply having to live with the fact that while his yatra had consolidated a Hindu vote bank, it also led to communal riots. The divisive nature of that period in Indian politics meant that Advani could never become prime minister when the BJP first came to power in 1996, that honour going to Vajpayee instead. Vajpayee was seen as a statesman in the Nehruvian mould; Advani had been pigeonholed as a Hindutva ideologue.

And yet, the Karachi-born, Jesuit school-educated, English-speaking leader, who liked a Naipaul novel as much as he did a Hindi film, was always looking to evolve and reinvent himself. In 2005, he went to Pakistan and described Jinnah as 'secular' and an 'ambassador of Hindu–Muslim unity'. The remarks sparked off a controversy within the Sangh Parivar for whom Pakistan's founder is a hate figure. Advani had to eventually step down as BJP president. It was almost as if his roots in the RSS would prevent him from breaking free from his past.

It was Advani's ideological training in the Sangh that also, in a sense, defined his relationship with Modi. As a committed organization man,